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Partnerships: From Entente to Rivalry to Cold War

China's and India's policies towards each other are driven not just by negative perceptions of each other and the quarrel over perimeters but also by their partnerships with the USSR/Russia and the US. To be clear, partnerships – sometimes called strategic partnerships – are different from alliances. Alliances are formal obligations to come to the aid of another against an enemy, usually clearly identified. Strategic partnerships – or partnerships for short – are much looser and refer to a broad set of understandings to consult and cooperate. The objectives of partnerships can vary, from exchanges of ideas and information, to coordinated actions against a common threat, to building up each other's capabilities. Partners may therefore collaborate diplomatically, share intelligence, and transfer weaponry among themselves. They may give each other preferential economic treatment and share technology as a way of growing their strength. They may even invest in building broader capabilities in each other's societies including in education or research. Deepening people-to-people ties through tourism, culture, and sports may also be part of the partnership toolkit. Strategic partnerships do not necessarily entail an obligation to fight alongside each other.

The relationship between India, China, the USSR/Russia, and the US can be described in two broad periods. The first period is from 1949 to 1988, when India and China moved from a brief entente against the US to open rivalry with each other by 1959. The entente was not a strategic partnership, but rather a convergence of interests in opposing 'neo-